

before the army arrived. They even applied the torch themselves, using scorched-earth tactics to foil the bummers.

The devastation inevitably got out of control, and was further aggravated by groups of deserters and renegades. Even the Confederate cavalry—now branded “Wheeler’s robbers”—let discipline slip. And, to complicate matters, thousands of formerly enslaved people, who were jubilant, were swept up in the wake of the march.

■ \$100
MILLION

Sherman’s estimate of damages inflicted during the march. A fifth of this was militarily justified, the “remainder ... simple waste and destruction.”

Savannah in sight

By early December, as the army skirted the low country swamps and marched beneath trees festooned with Spanish moss, Sherman’s increasingly scruffy soldiers were being called the “Lost Army” by the North. The men emerged into view by December 11, “within sight of the spires of Savannah,” one of them wrote, “if there were not so many trees in the way.”

Savannah was garrisoned by 10,000 soldiers and was protected by a ring of defenses mounting over 100 siege guns. But the packed-earth Fort McAllister, 12 miles (19km) below the city, was Sherman’s main concern. It had long defied Union warships; but on December 13, in an all-out assault, his infantrymen stormed through the circle of sharpened stakes and mounted the parapets. Its 230 defenders resisted bravely but futilely. Four days later, Sherman formally demanded the city’s surrender. The garrison commander, General Hardee, chose to evacuate instead. After dark on December 20, lit only by distant fires as the navy yard was set alight, a line of men and wagons moved across the Savannah River to South Carolina on a vast pontoon bridge. The next night the ironclad CSS *Savannah* exploded, lighting up the sky for miles. “The concussion was fearful,” one witness reported, “rocking the city.”

Sherman’s gift to Lincoln